

Systolic Blood Pressure

SBP (systolic blood pressure) is the top number in a blood pressure reading and represents the pressure in the arteries when the heart contracts and pumps blood out to the body. In most healthy adults, a typical SBP is generally around 90–120 mmHg, though this can vary with age, activity level, stress, and medical conditions (American Heart Association, 2024). A triage nurse pays close attention to SBP because it is a rapid indicator of a patient's circulatory stability: a low SBP may suggest life-threatening problems such as shock, dehydration, or internal bleeding where organs are not receiving enough blood flow, while a very high SBP can indicate hypertension and increased risk of acute complications such as stroke or cardiac strain (Mayo Clinic, 2023). Because SBP can change quickly and reflects overall cardiovascular function, it is one of the first vital signs used to prioritise urgency of care in emergency settings (National Institute for Health and Care Excellence [NICE], 2019).

Sources

American Heart Association. (2024). *Understanding blood pressure readings*.

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Mayo Clinic. (2023). *High blood pressure (hypertension)*.

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National Institute for Health and Care Excellence. (2019). *Hypertension in adults: diagnosis and management (NG136)*. <https://www.nice.org.uk/guidance/ng136>